

60-DAY PRACTICE PLAN

A structured daily practice guide for making the Rhythm Code instinctual.
Book: "The Rhythm Code" by Tamas Bodzsar

- 10-15 min/day
- 4 phases
- 18 weekly drills
- 5 anchor songs
- 4 milestones

DAILY SESSION STRUCTURE (EVERY DAY)

2 min
Pulse Lock
Put on a song. Find the beat. Clap on 1, 2, 3, 4. Then try to clap the tresillo (positions 1, and2, beat4). This trains your ear to hear the pulse before the theory.

10-13 min
Today's Drill
See the weekly drill for this week. Each week has a specific focus rotating through the four phases. Do the drill fully — don't rush it.

2-3 min
Apply to Your Project
Take today's concept and apply it to something you are currently working on — your own song, a cover, or a composition exercise. One direct application per session.

THE 4 PHASES

PHASE 1
Hear the Grid
Days 1-15
→ Binary notation fluency
→ Upbeats vs. downbeats
→ Quality sensitivity (boring vs. groovy)
→ 8-position grid reading

PHASE 2
Stops & Anticipations
Days 16-30
→ Stop detection in melodies
→ Anticipation identification
→ Quarter note anticipation ear training
→ Stop vs. non-stop distinction

PHASE 3
Find the Clave
Days 31-45
→ Tresillo recognition across genres
→ 2-3 vs. 3-2 orientation ID
→ Transcribing clave from songs
→ Clave in stops and starting points

PHASE 4
Build With the Code
Days 46-60
→ Rhythm Code map application
→ 4-step groove building method
→ Original groove composition
→ Multi-instrument Rhythm Code writing

WEEK-BY-WEEK DRILLS (18 WEEKS)

WEEK 1 · PHASE 1
Binary Transcription
Take 3 songs. Write the first 2 measures of the main melody in binary notation (mark ● where notes start). Compare your transcriptions — do they look similar to each other?

WEEK 2 · PHASE 1
Upbeat/Downbeat Audit
Mark U or D under each note in a 2-measure melody. Count the ratio. Then shift 2 notes from D to U (one position earlier). Listen to both versions. Note the difference in feel.

WEEK 3 · PHASE 1
The Quality Test
Play or sing a melody with ALL notes on downbeats. Then systematically shift 1, then 2, then 3 notes to upbeats. Record each version. Hear how the energy changes with each shift.

WEEK 4 · PHASE 1 — CHECKPOINT
Phase 1 Check
Can you instantly label every position (1, +, 2, +, 3, +, 4, +) on any song in real time? Put on 5 different songs and call out positions aloud as you listen. If yes, move to Phase 2.

WEEK 5 · PHASE 2
Stop Hunting
Identify all stops in 3 melodies — mark them in the binary grid. Then record: how many stops per phrase? What positions do they fall on? Are there patterns?

WEEK 6 · PHASE 2
Anticipation Spotting
Find every anticipation in a verse + chorus of one song. Mark: is each upbeat stop followed by an empty downbeat? That's an anticipation. Count regular vs. quarter note anticipations.

WEEK 7 · PHASE 2
Quarter Note Anticipation Hunt
Find 5 songs that use the quarter note anticipation (note on "and of 4," beat 1 of next measure empty). Examples to start: "Beautiful Day" (U2), "Say" (John Mayer), "I'm Every Woman" (Whitney).

WEEK 8 · PHASE 2 — CHECKPOINT
Phase 2 Check
Can you find stops and anticipations in a song WITHOUT looking at notation — just by listening? Test on "Happy" (Pharrell). Identify 5 stops and 3 anticipations by ear alone.

WEEK 9 · PHASE 3
Tresillo in Songs
Find the tresillo (1 0 0 1 0 0 1 0) in 5 songs. Required: "Hound Dog" (Elvis), "Shape of You" (Ed Sheeran), "Despacito" (Luis Fonsi). Choose 2 more from any genre.

WEEK 10 · PHASE 3
Clap the Clave
For 5 songs, clap the 3-2 or 2-3 son clave as you listen. Does it fit? Does it feel natural? Use "Happy" and "Get Up" as warm-up — these have very clear clave patterns to match against.

WEEK 11 · PHASE 3
Clave Direction ID
Identify 2-3 vs. 3-2 for 5 different songs using only the kick drum and bass. The direction is usually set by where the first clave note falls relative to the measure structure.

WEEK 12 · PHASE 3 — CHECKPOINT
Phase 3 Check
Transcribe a full verse of one song in binary notation. Mark which stops land on clave positions. Is it 2-3 or 3-2? Can you identify this in under 2 minutes of listening?

WEEK 13 · PHASE 4
Overlay the Map
Take a transcribed melody and mark STRONG / MEDIUM / AVOID for each stop using the Rhythm Code map. Count how many stops fall on each category. Compare "Happy" to "Get Up."

WEEK 14 · PHASE 4
Find the Off-Clave Rhythm Code Note
Find 2 songs where a stop fits the Rhythm Code map (STRONG position) but is NOT a clave note. This reveals positions the map covers that the clave itself doesn't include.

WEEK 15 · PHASE 4
The 4-Step Method
Take a simple melody you composed (or borrow a boring one). Apply all 4 steps: add QNA, anticipate the 3-side first beat, remove AVOID stops, anticipate beat 3. Compare before and after by recording both.

WEEK 16 · PHASE 4
Compose 3 Bass Lines
Write 3 original bass lines using the Rhythm Code. One 2-3 clave, one 3-2 clave, one of your choice. Record them. Play them back. Evaluate which stops land on STRONG positions.

WEEK 17 · PHASE 4
Full Song Groove

WEEK 18 · PHASE 4 — FINAL
Composition + Assessment

Write all 4 parts (kick drum, bass, guitar/keys, vocal melody) for a 2-measure groove using the Rhythm Code. Most stops should land on STRONG positions. Record and evaluate.

Compose a complete song section (verse + chorus, 16+ measures) using everything learned. Record it. Transcribe it. Map the stops. Calculate your STRONG/MEDIUM/AVOID ratio. Celebrate the result.

THE 5 ANCHOR SONGS

RECOMMENDED ANALYSIS SONGS — LEARN THESE FIRST

"Happy"

Pharrell Williams

2-3 Clave • Very clear • Start here

"Get Up"

James Brown

2-3 Clave • Historic • Funk reference

"Single Ladies"

Beyoncé

2-3 Clave • Pop + R&B • Modern

"Every Teardrop"

Coldplay

3-2 Clave • Rock • Guitar + vocal

Your choice

Any genre you love

Pick one anchor song from your genre

THE 4 MILESTONES

Day 15

"Can you label upbeats vs. downbeats in ANY song in real time — while just listening?"

Day 30

"Can you find stops and anticipations in a song without notation — by ear alone?"

Day 45

"Can you clap the clave while listening to 5 different songs across 5 different genres?"

Day 60

"Have you composed a groove using the 4-step Rhythm Code method and recorded it?"